

Lithuania 2024 Human Rights Report

Executive Summary

There were no significant changes in the human rights situation in Lithuania during the year.

There were no credible reports of significant human rights abuses.

The government took credible steps to identify and punish officials who committed human rights abuses.

Section 1. Life

a. Extrajudicial Killings

There were no reports the government or its agents committed arbitrary or unlawful killings during the year.

b. Coercion in Population Control

There were no reports of coerced abortion or involuntary sterilization on the part of government authorities.

Section 2. Liberty

a. Freedom of the Press

The constitution provided for freedom of expression, including for members of the press and other media, and the government respected this right. An independent media, an effective judiciary, and a functioning democratic political system combined to promote freedom of expression, including for media members.

The constitutional definition of freedom of expression did not permit slander; disinformation; or incitement to violence, discrimination, or national, racial, religious, or social hatred. Inciting hatred against a group of persons was punishable by imprisonment for up to two years. Inciting violence against a group of persons was punishable by imprisonment for up to three years. To deny or “grossly to trivialize” Soviet or Nazi German crimes against the country or its citizens or to deny genocide, crimes against humanity, or war crimes, was illegal.

Censorship by Governments, Military, Intelligence, or Police Forces, Criminal Groups, or Armed Extremist or Rebel Groups

A 2022 amendment to the Law on the Provision of Information to the Public imposed a temporary ban on rebroadcasting and online distribution of radio, television, or individual broadcasts by entities established, directly or

indirectly owned, controlled, or financed by the governments of Russia or Belarus. Channels distributed by EU countries were exempted from the ban. In June, parliament adopted further amendments to specify the extent to which broadcasting Russian and Belarusian broadcasts could be prohibited. The amendments stated that the ban would remain as long as Russia and Belarus were designated in the National Security Strategy as posing a danger or threat to the national security of the country.

In September 2023, the Radio and Television Commission blocked 53 internet addresses that provided access to Russian television channels and prohibited them from broadcasting in the country.

b. Worker Rights

Freedom of Association and Collective Bargaining

The law provided for the right of workers, except members of the armed forces, to form and join independent unions, bargain collectively, and conduct legal strikes. The law prohibited employer discrimination against union organizers and members and required reinstatement of workers fired for union activity. These provisions also applied to migrant workers.

There were some specific legal limits to these rights. The law prohibited sympathy strikes. The law did not afford workers in essential services, whose right to strike was restricted or prohibited, alternative procedures for

impartial and rapid settlement of their claims or a voice in developing such procedures.

Labor-management disputes were settled by a labor arbitration board formed under the jurisdiction of the district court where the registered office of the enterprise or entity involved in the collective dispute was located. Although the law established the binding character of the decision upon the parties, the decisions could not lay down rights or obligations of individuals and were not enforceable by the courts. Labor code procedures made it difficult for some workers to exercise the right to strike. The law allowed an employer to hire replacement workers in certain sectors to provide for minimum services during strikes.

The government generally respected freedom of association, collective bargaining, and the right to strike for workers, but it did not effectively enforce applicable laws. Penalties were regularly applied but were less than those for other laws involving denials of civil rights such as discrimination. Persistent harassment and intimidation of employees, commonly called mobbing, occurred in the workplace. According to the International Trade Union Confederation, the judicial system was slow to respond to cases of unfair dismissal and no employer faced penal sanctions for antiunion discrimination. No courts or judges specialized in labor disputes.

Employers did not always respect collective bargaining rights and managers often determined wages without regard to union preferences, except in

large factories with well-organized unions.

Forced or Compulsory Labor

See the Department of State's annual *Trafficking in Persons Report* at <https://www.state.gov/trafficking-in-persons-report/>.

Acceptable Work Conditions

Wage and Hour Laws

The national monthly minimum wage was higher than the poverty income level and applied to all sectors. The standard workweek was 40 hours. The Labor Code allowed an employee to work a maximum of 60 hours in a seven-day period. Employees could not work more than eight hours of overtime during a period of seven consecutive calendar days, unless the employee consented in writing to work up to 12 hours of overtime per week. The maximum overtime per year was 180 hours. For overtime work, a wage of at least one and a half times the salary of an employee was paid. For overtime work on a day off, or overtime work at night, no less than double the employee's salary was paid, and for overtime work on a holiday, no less than two and a half times the employee's salary.

The State Labor Inspectorate reported that the most common disputes between employers and employees involved delayed wages, the legality of dismissals, and claims for non-pecuniary damages. The construction sector,

the transport industry, small and medium-sized enterprises, and the service sector reported these violations most frequently.

Occupational Safety and Health

Occupational safety and health (OSH) standards were appropriate for the main industries in the country, such as petroleum refining, food processing, energy supplies, chemicals, furniture, wood products, textiles, and clothing. Occupational risk was assessed by each company. The law applied to both national and foreign workers. The government conducted proactive inspections for unsafe conditions. Workers could remove themselves from situations that endangered health or safety without jeopardy to their employment. Violations of health and safety standards were more common in construction, manufacturing, and wholesale and retail trade companies.

Wage, Hour, and OSH Enforcement

The government effectively enforced minimum wage, overtime, and OSH laws. Penalties were commensurate with those for similar crimes and were regularly applied against violators. Penalties were related primarily to workplace accidents and occupational illnesses. The State Labor Inspectorate was responsible for implementing labor laws and made efforts to do so in both the formal and informal sectors. The inspectorate had a staff sufficient to enforce compliance. Workers dissatisfied with the results of an investigation could appeal to the court system.

Inspectors had the authority to make unannounced inspections and initiate sanctions. Workers had the legal right to request compensation for health concerns arising from dangerous working conditions. During the first half of the year, the Labor Inspectorate identified 2,371 persons who worked illegally in companies, farms, and for private individuals.

The government took measures to prevent labor violations, including adopting a legal framework and mechanisms to protect vulnerable groups.

According to the National Statistics Department, in 2022, unofficial economic activity accounted for approximately 12.6 percent of GDP. The government enforced labor laws in the informal economy whenever informal or illegal activity was uncovered.

c. Disappearance and Abduction

Disappearance

There were no reports of enforced disappearances by or on behalf of government authorities.

Prolonged Detention without Charges

The law prohibited arbitrary arrest and detention and provided for the right of any person to challenge the lawfulness of their arrest or detention in court. The government generally observed these requirements.

d. Violations in Religious Freedom

See the Department of State's annual *International Religious Freedom Report* at <https://www.state.gov/religiousfreedomreport/>.

e. Trafficking in Persons

See the Department of State's annual *Trafficking in Persons Report* at <https://www.state.gov/trafficking-in-persons-report/>.

Section 3. Security of the Person

a. Torture and Cruel, Inhuman, or Degrading Treatment or Punishment

The constitution and law prohibited such practices, and there were no credible reports government officials employed them.

b. Protection of Children

Child Labor

The law prohibited all of the worst forms of child labor. The statutory minimum age for employment was 15, and it applied to children working in all sectors. Children age 13 or older could perform light work with permission from a parent. Teenagers who were no longer subject to

compulsory full-time education under national law could work up to eight hours a day and 40 hours a week. The law prohibited children younger than 18 from performing nighttime or overtime work, or in jobs that posed a risk to their physical safety, health, or development. The government effectively enforced child labor laws. Penalties were commensurate with those for other analogous serious crimes and were regularly applied against violators. There was no significant presence of the worst forms of child labor.

Child Marriage

The legal minimum age for marriage was 18 and was effectively enforced by the government.

c. Protection to Refugees

The government cooperated with the Office of the UN High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) and other humanitarian organizations in providing protection and assistance to refugees, returning refugees, or asylum seekers, as well as other persons of concern.

Provision of First Asylum

The law provided for the granting of asylum or refugee status, and the government had a system for providing protection to refugees. Some asylum seekers, mostly from the Middle East and Africa, crossed into the country from Belarus. Following a maximum statutory length of one year in

detention, many left Lithuania and traveled on to other countries in the EU.

In April 2023, parliament adopted amendments to the Law on the State Border and Its Protection, legalizing the turning back of irregular migrants who entered the country from Belarus outside of authorized border checkpoints. The State Border Guard Service estimated they refused entry to more than 22,300 individuals who attempted entry into Lithuania from Belarus since 2021.

UNHCR stated the new law fell short of offering sufficient protections and legal options for those seeking protection, could authorize “pushbacks,” and could potentially lead to individuals not being granted effective access to the right to seek asylum. Amnesty International and local human rights organizations criticized the law.

d. Acts of Antisemitism and Antisemitic Incitement

The Jewish community consisted of 2,256 persons based on 2021 census data. There were reports of antisemitism on the internet and in public. Several incidents of vandalism targeting Jewish sites occurred.

On April 25, the Constitutional Tribunal of Lithuania ruled that parliament member Remigijus Zemaitaitis broke his oath and violated the constitution by posting antisemitic content on Facebook in May and June 2023. He posted additional antisemitic material in October 2023, following the terrorist attacks by Hamas in Israel. The Constitutional Court concluded that

Zemaitaitis deliberately, purposefully, and systematically published statements that humiliated the dignity and promoted hate against a group of persons because of their nationality. Following a pretrial investigation into Zemaitaitis' statements, the Vilnius Regional Prosecutor's Office concluded on April 26 that the politician was suspected of inciting hatred against Jews and showing public approval of Nazi crimes. On April 29, Zemaitaitis resigned from parliament.

For further information on incidents of antisemitism, and for reporting on the ability of Jews to exercise freedom of religion or belief, please see the Department of State's annual *International Religious Freedom Report* at <https://www.state.gov/religiousfreedomreport/>.